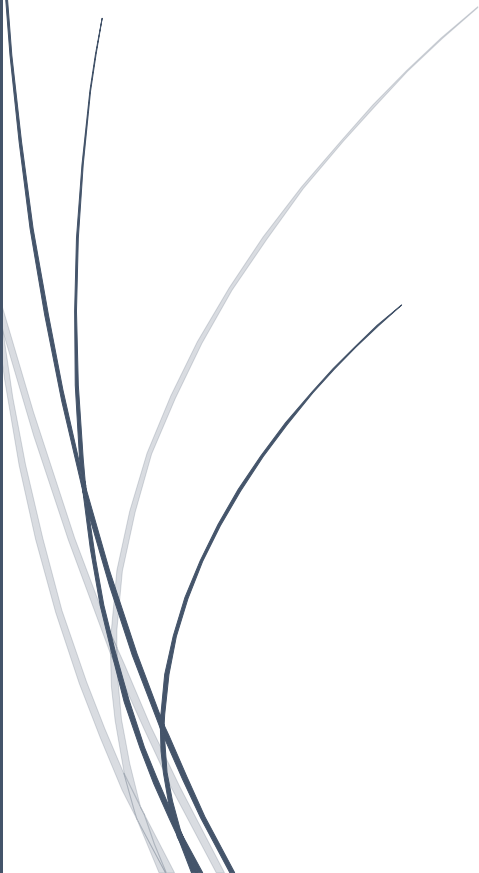


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WEEK 8

Community engagement

- Concept
 - nature and characteristics of community
 - community development and social cohesion
- 
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Community engagement

Community engagement is a collaborative process where people, organizations, and institutions work together to address issues and promote well-being within a community, fostering stronger relationships and shared responsibility.

Community engagement seeks to engage community to achieve sustainable outcomes, equitable decision-making processes, and deepen relationships and trust between government organizations and communities.

To better understand the meaning of community engagement, we can break down each word:

Community – Groups of people based on common geography (country, state, region, suburb, neighborhood, etc.) or common interest (customs, values, religion, needs, etc.), which may include citizens, businesses, residents, stakeholders, and more.

Nature of Community:

Communities provide a sense of belonging and support for their members. Community members often work together towards common goals and objectives. Communities can be inclusive and welcoming, fostering a sense of unity and cooperation.

Characteristics of Community

Community members often engage in regular social interactions and activities. Communities may have established norms, traditions, and rituals that help define their identity. Community members often share a sense of responsibilities and mutual concern for each other.

Importance of Community

Communities play a vital role in promoting social cohesion and enhancing individual well-being. Community involvement can lead to increased social support, resilience, and a sense of purpose. Strong communities can contribute to positive social change and improved quality of life for their members.

Engagement – The act of including stakeholders in activities and communications and allowing them to contribute in a meaningful way

The **United Nations Community Engagement Guidelines on Peacebuilding and Sustaining Peace** also includes a usual definition for what community engagement is:

“Community engagement” is a strategic process to directly involve local populations in all aspects of decision-making, policy development and implementation to strengthen local ownership, capacities and community structures as well as to improve transparency, accountability and optimal resource allocations across diverse settings.

Empowering community members to explore, plan and act together on their priority issues can be a powerful way to strengthen collective capacity and improve programme equity and effectiveness. This requires community members, leaders and organizations to play a central role in the development of humanitarian initiatives that affect them.

Community Engagement also seeks to strengthen the link between people and the systems, structures and services—both formal and informal—that have been designed to meet their needs. This means strengthening governance, quality of service delivery and systems, and improving accountability mechanisms. Through Community Engagement, UNICEF aims to support countries in establishing lasting mechanisms for participatory ideation, planning, implementation and monitoring. By collaborating with external partners, especially governmental and community led organizations, UNICEF strives to enhance social accountability.

Community Engagement Principles

Several principles guide community engagement.

- Community engagement is most effective when it involves a collaborative effort that brings together community members, organizations, and groups working towards a common goal. Collaboration fosters a sense of ownership and responsibility among community members and a shared commitment to achieving positive outcomes.
- Collaboration leads to another essential principle of community engagement: empowerment. Empowerment involves providing community members with the tools, knowledge, and resources to participate in decision-making and problem-solving. This may include providing training or educational resources and creating opportunities for community members to take on leadership roles and become more involved.
- Inclusivity is another vital principle of community engagement. Inclusivity involves ensuring all community members have a voice and an opportunity to participate in the process, including those who may be traditionally marginalized or underrepresented. Inclusion may involve reaching out to community members in different languages or through various channels and providing accommodations or support for those with disabilities or other special needs.

- An empowered and inclusive community engagement strategy also features respect as another critical principle. Respect involves acknowledging and honoring the values, beliefs, and cultures of the community and its members. This may include seeking input from community members on their cultural practices or customs and being mindful of potential cultural barriers or biases that may impact the engagement process.
- To build trust with the community, they must feel like you are open and forthright in conducting business. You must hold transparency as another principle for effective community engagement. Transparency involves providing clear and concise information about the project or initiative, including its goals, timelines, and potential impacts. This may include providing regular updates or progress reports and being open and honest about potential challenges or limitations of the process.

Types of Community Engagement:

1. **Direct Service:** This involves hands-on activities that directly impact individuals or groups, such as volunteering at a local food bank or cleaning up a park. In Pakistan, many people volunteer during Ramadan to distribute food and other essentials to those in need. This is an example of direct service where community members engage with others through charity and social work.

2. **Advocacy:** Advocacy refers to efforts to influence policies or decisions by raising awareness, lobbying, or campaigning for change.

Advocacy engagement involves actively involving individuals and communities in efforts to promote specific causes or policies, aiming to create positive change through raising awareness, influencing policies, and mobilizing resources

3. **Social Innovation:** Social innovation involves creating new strategies or ideas to solve community problems in creative ways. In Pakistan, youth-led startups are often focused on using technology to solve issues like unemployment, waste management, or education access. These innovations help the community by finding new and efficient solutions to long-standing problems.

4. **Consultation:** Consultation is the process of seeking input from the community on important decisions, such as urban planning or environmental regulations. In some countries, local government bodies sometimes hold town hall meetings where citizens are invited to give their input on new development projects or policies. This helps ensure that the community's views are considered before decisions are made.

5. **Capacity Building:** Capacity building involves training and educating community members so they can better understand issues and contribute to problem-solving. Non-governmental

organizations (NGOs) in Pakistan often conduct capacity-building workshops in rural areas to teach skills like farming techniques, literacy, or financial management, enabling people to become more self-sufficient and active in their communities.

so capacity building involves strengthening a community's ability to address its own needs through various approaches, including developing skills, fostering leadership, and promoting resource utilization.

Characteristics of Community Engagement:

Community engagement is a process where Individuals, groups, and organizations come together to work on solving common problems or improving the community. It involves various activities, such as volunteering, participating in discussions, or supporting local initiatives. Here are the main characteristics of community engagement explained in simple words:

1. **Inclusive:** Community engagement involves everyone, no matter their background, age, gender, or status. It makes sure that all voices are heard and everyone has the opportunity to participate. Inclusiveness means that the rich, poor, men, women, children, elderly, and people with different abilities or beliefs can all be part of the engagement process.
2. **Collaborative:** People work together to achieve common goals. Community engagement is about teamwork and cooperation between different individuals and groups. When people pool their resources, ideas, and energy, they can tackle challenges more effectively. Collaboration helps build strong connections between people and organizations. After floods in Pakistan, many organizations, government bodies, and local communities join hands to provide relief, showing the power of collaboration.
3. **Empowering:** Community engagement helps people feel strong and capable of making changes in their community. It gives them the tools, knowledge, and confidence to take action. Engagement empowers individuals by making them realize that their participation can make a difference in their surroundings. It turns ordinary people into active contributors.
4. **Respectful:** Community engagement respects the opinions, ideas, and needs of all participants. It values diversity and encourages people to share their views in a respectful manner. Engagement activities create an environment where everyone feels safe to speak and be heard, even if their opinions are different from others.
5. **Transparent:** Transparency means that the decisions and actions taken during community engagement are open, honest, and clear to everyone involved. Participants are informed about how decisions are made, how funds are spent, and how progress is being tracked. This builds trust within the community.

7. Problem-Solving: Community engagement focuses on finding solutions to the problems or challenges faced by the community. It encourages people to work together to overcome difficulties. People come together to identify the issues affecting their community, share ideas, and implement solutions to solve them.

Approaches to Effective Community Engagement:

Traditional Approaches:

- **Public Meetings:** Open meetings where community members discuss issues or plans. Encourages direct interaction between citizens and authorities. It's a platform for open discussion where people can voice their opinion.
- **Workshops and Seminars:** Training sessions where people learn about issues and solutions. Provides education but may only attract those already interested.
- **Surveys and Questionnaires:** Collect opinions from a large number of people.
- **Focus Groups:** Small groups discuss specific topics in depth, providing detailed insights.
- **Door-to-Door Campaigns:** Personal visits to raise awareness or gather feedback.

Modern Approaches:

- **Online Platforms and Websites:** Use of websites or apps for community engagement, allowing people to access information and provide feedback.
- **Crowdsourcing:** Gathering ideas or solutions from a large group of people online, often used for problem-solving.
- **Participatory Budgeting:** A democratic process where community members decide how part of the public budget is spent, increasing transparency and citizen involvement.
- **Mobile Applications (Apps):** Apps allow real-time interaction, such as reporting issues or accessing government services.
- **Virtual Town Halls and Webinars:** Online meetings or educational sessions that reach a broader audience, especially useful for those who cannot attend in person.
- **Social Media Campaigns:** Using platforms like Facebook, Twitter, and Instagram to engage the community, spread awareness, and gather feedback.

Community Development and Social Cohesion:

Community Development: Community development is the process of improving a community's well-being by helping people work together to solve common problems and build a better environment. It involves making social, economic, and environmental improvements by empowering individuals and groups in the community. This process can include building schools, improving healthcare, providing better jobs, or organizing social events. In a village, the people

come together to build a water well, so everyone has access to clean drinking water. This project improves the quality of life and brings people closer, as they all contribute to the community's well-being.

Social Cohesion: Social cohesion means how well the people in a society or community get along with each other. It's about unity, mutual trust, and working together. A society with high social cohesion is one where people help each other, respect each other's differences, and live in harmony despite their diverse backgrounds. In a multicultural city, people from different religions, languages, and ethnic groups live peacefully together. They celebrate each other's festivals and work together to solve community issues, showing strong social cohesion.

Community development and social cohesion are deeply interconnected, each reinforcing the other in a positive cycle. When people work together on projects like improving schools, parks, or local businesses, they build trust and cooperation, strengthening social cohesion as they share experiences and form stronger bonds. For instance, cleaning and beautifying a local park not only improves the area but also encourages interaction, increasing unity and trust. In communities where social cohesion is already strong, starting and completing development projects becomes easier because individuals feel a sense of belonging and are more motivated to support common goals, such as building a community center. As social cohesion improves, community development progresses more effectively, and successful projects, like building a community garden, further reinforce social cohesion by fostering pride and trust. This mutual support cycle encourages even more ambitious initiatives, like setting up a community library, continuously enhancing both community development and social cohesion.

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